

Psalm 21

The King's Joy in God's Strength

The king shall joy in thy strength, O Lord
KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 *The king shall joy in thy strength, O LORD; and in thy salvation how greatly shall he rejoice!*
- 2 *Thou hast given him his heart's desire, and hast not withholden the request of his lips. Selah.*
- 3 *For thou preventest him with the blessings of goodness: thou settest a crown of pure gold on his head.*
- 4 *He asked life of thee, and thou gavest it him, even length of days for ever and ever.*
- 5 *His glory is great in thy salvation: honour and majesty hast thou laid upon him.*
- 6 *For thou hast made him most blessed for ever: thou hast made him exceeding glad with thy countenance.*
- 7 *For the king trusteth in the LORD, and through the mercy of the most High he shall not be moved.*
- 8 *Thine hand shall find out all thine enemies: thy right hand shall find out those that hate thee.*
- 9 *Thou shalt make them as a fiery oven in the time of thine anger: the LORD shall swallow them up in his wrath, and the fire shall devour them.*
- 10 *Their fruit shalt thou destroy from the earth, and their seed from among the children of men.*
- 11 *For they intended evil against thee: they imagined a mischievous device, which they are not able to perform.*
- 12 *Therefore shalt thou make them turn their back, when thou shalt make ready thine arrows upon thy strings against the face of them.*
- 13 *Be thou exalted, LORD, in thine own strength: so will we sing and praise thy power.*

2 · CONTEXT

Psalm 21 answers Psalm 20's prayer with celebration: the king already rejoices in salvation and strength granted by God, crowned, blessed, and secured against enemies. Read historically of David (and Israel's kings), it also carries messianic overtones the New Testament associates with Christ's exaltation and everlasting reign; Henry treats the psalm as thanksgiving that models gratitude for answered prayer as much as petition modeled faith in seeking it.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-2

Opening celebration: the king rejoices in God's strength and salvation; God has given him his heart's desire and not withheld the request of his lips—direct fulfillment of the prayers of Psalm 20.

Verse 3-6

God "prevented" (went before) him with blessings of goodness, set a crown of pure gold on his head, granted long life, great glory, honor, and majesty, and made him exceeding glad with God's own presence—royal favor described as sheer divine gift, not achievement.

Verse 7-10

Because the king trusts in the Lord, through the mercy of the Most High he shall not be moved; God's hand will find out His enemies, and they will be consumed and destroyed like fruit in fire—vivid confidence that opposition to the God-appointed king cannot ultimately prevail.

Verse 11-13

Recap of the enemies' imagined mischief which they are not able to perform, since they will be turned back and made to flee. The psalm closes with worship: "Be thou exalted, Lord, in thine own strength: so will we sing praise."

4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

A ruler's security, joy, and lasting honor come as gifts from God's strength and favor, and confidence that opposition to God's appointed king will ultimately fail belongs to worship, not anxiety.

Application for life today.

Practice celebrating specific answered prayers as deliberately as you bring petitions—name the blessings that “prevented” (went ahead of) you before you even asked. Let this psalm reframe any position of leadership or influence you hold as a trust from God’s strength rather than self-made accomplishment. And when opposition to what God is doing seems threatening, let verse 13’s posture—exalting God rather than fixating on the threat—shape your response.

5 • REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. What specific blessing has God given you ahead of your asking (“prevented... with blessings”), and have you thanked Him for it?

2. How does viewing any authority or influence you have as a gift from God’s strength change how you use it?

3. Where do you need to shift from anxious focus on opposition to the worshipful confidence of verse 13?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).